



LESSON 6.3 – SUPERIMPOSING PENTATONIC SCALES OVER DIATONIC MODES

UNLOCKING MODAL SOLOING THROUGH THE PENTATONIC LENS

WHY SUPERIMPOSE PENTATONICS OVER DIATONIC MODES?

The pentatonic scale—especially the minor pentatonic—is a highly accessible and expressive tool. But its real power emerges when you begin to superimpose it over diatonic modes, turning five simple notes into a palette of modal colours.

Using this technique, you can:

- Add familiar phrasing to complex modal progressions.
- Unlock expressive options without memorising entire modal scale shapes.
- Bridge blues, rock, and fusion genres with modal sophistication.

♦ Foundation: The 5-Box System Recap

The 5 box shapes of the minor pentatonic scale (e.g. E minor pentatonic: E–G–A–B–D) stay consistent no matter which mode you're overlaying them on. The power lies in how the pentatonic notes relate to the mode and the underlying chords.

MINOR PENTATONIC SUPERIMPOSED ON MINOR MODES

1. E Aeolian (Natural Minor)

Scale: E – F# – G – A – B – C – D

Overlay: E Minor Pentatonic omits F# and C (2nd & 6th)

Used by: Gary Moore, Zakk Wylde

2. E Dorian

Scale: E – F# – G – A – B – C# – D

Overlay: E Minor Pentatonic omits F# and C#

Used by: Santana, John McLaughlin

3. E Phrygian

Scale: E – F – G – A – B – C – D

Overlay: E Minor Pentatonic omits F and C

Used by: Marty Friedman, Kirk Hammett

MAJOR PENTATONIC SUPERIMPOSED ON MAJOR MODES

1. G Ionian (Major Scale)

Scale: G – A – B – C – D – E – F#

Overlay: G Major Pentatonic omits C and F#

Used in pop, country, classic rock

2. G Lydian

Scale: G – A – B – C# – D – E – F#



Overlay: G Major Pentatonic omits C# and F#
Used by: Steve Vai, Joe Satriani

3. G Mixolydian

Scale: G – A – B – C – D – E – F

Overlay: G Major Pentatonic omits C and F
Used in funk, blues rock, jam band solos

QUICK REFERENCE TABLE

This reference table outlines how both minor and major pentatonic scales can be superimposed over specific diatonic modes to shape melodic expression and expand improvisational possibilities.

Mode	Root	Characteristic Notes	Pentatonic Used	Notes Omitted	Colour/Effect
Aeolian	E	b6 (C)	E Minor Pentatonic	F# (2nd), C (b6)	Pure minor vibe
Dorian	E	6 (C#)	E Minor Pentatonic	F# (2nd), C# (6th)	Funky, blues-rock fusion
Phrygian	E	b2 (F)	E Minor Pentatonic	F (b2), C (b6)	Dark but blues-flavoured
Ionian	G	7 (F#)	G Major Pentatonic	C (4th), F# (7th)	Bright and melodic
Lydian	G	#4 (C#)	G Major Pentatonic	C# (#4), F# (7th)	Uplifting with smooth edges
Mixolydian	G	b7 (F)	G Major Pentatonic	C (4th), F (b7)	Bluesy major, great for funk

HOW TO PRACTISE SUPERIMPOSITION

1. Choose a modal backing track (e.g. Dorian vamp).
2. Play through the appropriate minor or major pentatonic scale.
3. Target characteristic tones by ear (e.g. 6th in Dorian, #4 in Lydian).
4. Slide in blue notes or bends to colour your phrasing.
5. Switch between pentatonic and full modal scale to hear contrast.

EXAMPLES FROM ICONIC SONGS

- “Juice” – Steve Vai: A major & minor pentatonic over A Mixolydian.
- “Still Got the Blues” – Gary Moore: A minor pentatonic blended with A Aeolian & A Harmonic Minor.
- “Stairway to Heaven” – Led Zeppelin: A minor pentatonic and A Aeolian interplay.



Alien Guitar Secrets

CLOSING THOUGHTS

Superimposing pentatonics over modes expands your tonal vocabulary while keeping things grounded in the fretboard shapes you already know. This is the true bridge between modal theory and rock/blues instinct.

Your mission, Alien Guitarist, is to:

- Experiment.
- Explore modal backing tracks.
- Hear how each superimposed pentatonic scale reshapes the flavour of a mode.

🎸 The fretboard is your universe. Start bending space with modal pentatonics.

Peace, Rob Lobasso 🤖 🎸 🙌